



Above A reclining Buddha in the eccentric Buddha Park, constructed entirely from concrete by a Laotian mystic in the 1950s

A Day in Vientiane

One of the wonderful things about Vientiane is that the sights can be covered in one day: a pleasure best punctuated along the way with stops for a cup of fresh filtered Lao coffee or a glass of Lao beer.

MORNING Start with the **Ho Phra Kaew Art Museum**, a temple originally built to house the celebrated Emerald Buddha, later appropriated by Siam in 1779. Today it is a museum containing religious art. Then take in **Wat Phra That Luang**: this giant, golden Buddhist stupa is a defining symbol of Vientiane.

AFTERNOON The **National Museum**, in a rambling old colonial structure, is a fascinating collection of artifacts from various eras of Lao history. Then take a taxi 15 miles (24 km) along the river to the **Buddha Park**, a fanciful sculpture garden full of Hindu and Buddhist statuary.

EVENING Sunset over the Mekong is a show in itself. Back in town, if you're not heading for Nang Khambang for dinner, there are many traditional restaurants lining the river to the west of the main **riverfront promenade**. One of the best is Sala Khoun Ta.

Essentials

GETTING THERE

Wattay International Airport is a short **taxi** ride from the center of town. Alternatively, one can cross the **Mekong** from Thailand. Visa on arrival is available whichever route you choose.

WHERE TO STAY

Mali Namphu Guest House (inexpensive) is an atmospheric ocher-walled building constructed around a shaded courtyard. www.malinamphu.com

Hotel Khamvongsa (moderate) is brand-new and is situated in a converted French villa near the river. www.hotelkhamvongsa.com

Settha Palace Hotel (expensive) is a renovated French colonial masterpiece with great charm and excellent dining. www.setthapalace.com

TOURIST INFORMATION

www.tourismloos.org



Above Dozens of small, unpretentious restaurants and food stands hung with lanterns line the banks of the Mekong at night